

● ● ● AN EBOOK PRODUCTION GUIDE • EDITION ONE • 2026

FIELD MANUAL FOR THE SELF-PUBLISHED AUTHOR

Renaissance of the *Poor Soul*

*From manuscript to marketplace — a complete, no-fluff guide to
designing, formatting, and publishing your eBook on Amazon KDP and
beyond.*



PREPARED FOR
HALALISANI NGEMA

SECTIONS
I — IX

TIME TO SHIP
≈ 3 HOURS

TITLE	AUTHOR
Renaissance of the Poor Soul	Halalisani Ngema
FORMAT	CHANNELS
Reflowable EPUB 3	KDP · D2D · Smashwords · Kobo · Google Play

C O N T E N T S		
01	The Cover	SPECS • PROMPTS • PITFALLS
02	Interior Formatting	FRONT MATTER • BODY • BACK MATTER
03	Metadata & Keywords	LISTING COPY • ISBNs • CATEGORIES
04	Technical Export	WORD • CALIBRE • KINDLE PREVIEWER
05	Three-Hour Production Checklist	20 STEPS, TODAY
06	Final Verification	THREE PRE-FLIGHT TESTS
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08	If You Get Stuck	DECISION TREE
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SECTION I

The Cover

A cover that *works at thumbnail size*.

Most readers will see your cover the size of a postage stamp before they ever see it full-screen. Design for that first.

A SPIRITUAL REFLECTION

*Renaissance
of the Poor Soul*

ooo

A JOURNEY THROUGH THE MANY FACES OF THE HUMAN SPIRIT

1.1 Hard specifications

These are non-negotiable for Amazon KDP and safe for every other platform.

DIMENSIONS

1600 × 2560 px (1.6 : 1 ratio). 2500 × 4000 px is better if your designer can deliver it.

RESOLUTION

300 DPI

COLOUR MODE

RGB (not CMYK – eBook only)

FILE FORMAT

JPEG (preferred) or TIFF. Save quality at 90–100%.

MAX FILE SIZE

50 MB. Aim for under 5 MB.

BLEED / MARGIN

Keep all critical text 8% inside the edges (no bleed for eBooks).

1.2 What must appear on the cover

- **Title** – “Renaissance of the Poor Soul” – the dominant element. Test by squinting at a 200-px-tall thumbnail; the title must still be legible.
- **Subtitle** – “A journey through the many faces of the human spirit” – smaller, lighter, beneath the title.
- **Author name** – “Halalisani Ngema” – bottom third, in a smaller weight than the title but never illegible.

- **Optional motif** – a single quiet visual: a horizon, a candle flame, an open hand, a doorway, a single feather. *One* motif. Not three.

1.3 Type recommendations

Pair one display face for the title with one neutral face for subtitle and author. Avoid scripts, anything ultra-thin, and anything you’ve seen on a thousand other self-published covers.

DISPLAY (TITLE)

- Cormorant Garamond – literary, soulful
- Playfair Display – high-contrast, dramatic
- Cinzel – engraved, sacred-feeling
- Bodoni Moda – editorial, confident

SUPPORTING (SUBTITLE, AUTHOR)

- Lato – clean, warm sans
- Source Sans 3 – neutral, calm
- Montserrat – geometric, modern
- EB Garamond – serif consistency option

1.4 Colour direction for this book

Your manuscript is contemplative and spiritual – a memoir-meets-meditation on the soul. Treat the cover like a chapel wall, not a billboard.

- **Recommended palette** – deep indigo or charcoal as base, warm ochre or candle-gold as accent, soft cream for type. Optional muted sage for one secondary element.
- **Avoid** – bright reds, neon, heavy gradients, “mystical purple” clichés, stock-photo skies.
- If your topic ever shifts – *business* uses cool blue/grey; *self-help* uses warm earth tones; *memoir* uses muted, washed colour. Match your interior emotional tone.

1.5 AI image-generator prompt

Paste this into Midjourney, DALL·E, or Canva’s AI tool. Replace bracketed words to taste. Generate *backgrounds only*; lay your type on top in Canva or Affinity afterward.

```
// Prompt – atmospheric background, no text
A quiet, painterly scene evoking spiritual stillness:
a single candle burning in a vast dim chapel, soft golden light
falling on weathered stone, dust motes in the air, deep indigo
shadows. Inspired by chiaroscuro oil painting, Caravaggio-adjacent,
Andrew Wyeth restraint. Vertical composition, 1600x2560, leave the
upper third uncluttered for typography. Muted palette: indigo,
charcoal, ochre, cream. No text. No people. No watermark.
Photorealistic with painterly grain.

// Negative prompt
text, letters, watermark, neon, oversaturated, busy composition,
crowd, stock-photo cliché, glossy, plastic look
```

Generate four. Pick the one with the most negative space at the top – your title needs to live there.

1.6 What to avoid

- × Title smaller than 1/8 the cover height
- × White type on a light background – the #1 thumbnail killer
- × More than two typefaces
- × Three or more focal points (eye doesn't know where to land)
- × Stock photos that look like stock photos
- × Author name bigger than the title (unless you're famous)
- × Drop-shadowed type with default Photoshop bevel
- × Genre mismatch (no horror typography on a spiritual memoir)

THE SQUINT TEST

Export your cover at 200 px tall. Squint at it from arm's length. If you can read the title and feel the genre in two seconds, you're done. If not, simplify.

SECTION II

Interior Formatting

Reflowable EPUB, *built for every reader.*

Reflowable means the reader controls font size, theme, and line length. Your job is structure – let the device do the typesetting.

2.1 Front matter – in this exact order

① TITLE PAGE

Centre-aligned. Three lines, each on its own line, with breathing room.

TEMPLATE

RENAISSANCE OF THE POOR SOUL

A journey through the many faces of the human spirit

Halalisani Ngema

② COPYRIGHT PAGE

Customise this template. The AI-assistance disclosure is optional – include it only if you want to.

TEMPLATE

Renaissance of the Poor Soul

Copyright © 2026 Halalisani Ngema. All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means – electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise – without the prior written permission of the author, except for brief quotations in critical reviews and certain non-commercial uses permitted by copyright law.

First electronic edition, 2026. Published in South Africa.

eISBN: 978-1-0492-8329-6

Optional disclosure: Portions of this manuscript were drafted with the assistance of AI tools. All ideas, stories, and final language are the author’s own.

Cover design by [Designer Name]. Interior formatting by the author.

③ DEDICATION (OPTIONAL)

Centre-aligned, italic, brief. Yours already exists in the manuscript — keep it.

④ TABLE OF CONTENTS (AUTO-GENERATED, HYPERLINKED)

Do not type a TOC by hand. Use Word/Docs heading styles (see §4.1) and let the EPUB exporter build it. The TOC must *link* to each chapter, and every device's side-menu navigation depends on it.

⑤ FOREWORD / PREFACE (OPTIONAL)

One paragraph is enough. Tell the reader why *you* wrote this — the moment, the loss, the question that wouldn't leave you. Your existing Foreword does this beautifully; keep it.

2.2 Body formatting rules

BODY FONT

Serif preferred – Garamond, Georgia, Bookerly, Merriweather. Or sans – Lato, Open Sans, Helvetica. Pick *one*. Most reflowable readers will override anyway; default to a system serif.

BASE SIZE

12 pt (the reader will resize freely)

LINE HEIGHT

1.3 (range 1.2 – 1.4)

MARGINS

5 mm left / right; 0 mm header & footer (reflowable owns the chrome)

CHAPTER HEADING

Bold, 18 – 20 pt, centred or left. Add a divider beneath: ○ ○ ○ or a single rule.

FIRST PARAGRAPH

No indent after a chapter title or scene break

SUBSEQUENT PARAGRAPHS

1.2 em first-line indent, no extra blank line between

SCENE BREAKS

Centred ○ ○ ○ – one blank line above and below

JUSTIFICATION

Left-aligned (ragged right) – better than full justification on small screens

IMAGES

JPEG, max 800 px wide, centred, alt text required, file size < 200 KB each

HYPERLINKS

All URLs and cross-references clickable; underline on, no colour change needed

Your manuscript already uses ○ ○ ○ as a scene break — keep it. It matches the contemplative tone.

2.3 Back matter (optional but recommended)

- **About the author** — 2–3 sentences. Where you're from, what shaped this book, where readers can find you.
- **Other books** — placeholder line: “More from Halalisani Ngema — coming soon.”
- **Call to action** — “If this book helped you, please leave a review on Amazon. It takes one minute and changes everything for an independent author.”
- **Thank you** — single page, centred. “Thank you for reading.” Sign your name.

“Reflowable formatting is restraint. Don't fight the device — feed it clean structure and let it do its job.”

— PRODUCTION NOTE

SECTION III

Metadata & Keywords

Discoverability is *structured language*.
Eight fields decide whether your book ever gets found. Treat them like product copy, not paperwork.

3.1 Listing template – fill this in

TITLE

Renaissance of the Poor Soul

SUBTITLE

A journey through the many faces of the human spirit

AUTHOR

Halalisani Ngema

LANGUAGE

English

PUBLICATION DATE

The day you upload (auto-set)

ISBN

Already assigned – 978-1-0492-8329-6

3.2 Book description – 150–300 words

Use this five-beat structure. Hook → Problem → Solution → Benefit → Call to action.

DRAFT FOR YOU TO EDIT

Hook — What is the soul, and what happens to it when no one is watching?

Problem — We live in an age that has forgotten how to sit with the deeper questions. We chase noise. We medicate stillness. And somewhere underneath it all, the soul keeps asking the questions our culture refuses to entertain.

Solution — *Renaissance of the Poor Soul* is a slow, honest walk through the spiritual landscape of being human. Drawing on memory, scripture, and the quiet wisdom of his elders, Halalisani Ngema explores the many conditions a soul can find itself in — wandering, weeping, waiting, reborn.

Benefit — You won't find easy answers here. You will find company. A book that takes your interior life seriously, and treats the act of asking as sacred in itself.

Call to action — If you have ever sat alone with a question that wouldn't leave you — open the first page. Your time is coming.

3.3 Seven keywords — how to research them

Open Amazon. Type a phrase that describes your book and watch the auto-complete. Those suggestions are real searches real readers are typing right now. Pull seven that fit.

01 spiritual memoir	02 meditations on the soul
03 christian reflections	04 grief and faith
05 african spirituality	06 contemplative essays
07 healing and hope	

Replace any of these with whatever Amazon's search bar suggests when you type the first three words. Real auto-completes > my guesses.

3.4 Two categories

For a contemplative spiritual memoir, the safest two starting picks on KDP:

- Religion & Spirituality > Spirituality > Inspirational
- Biographies & Memoirs > Memoirs > Personal Memoirs

After launch, email kdp-categories@amazon.com and ask to be added to up to ten more sub-categories — this is free and underused.

3.5 ISBN — free or bought?

FREE (DRAFT2DIGITAL)

D2D assigns a free ISBN if you don't have one. Listed publisher is Draft2Digital.

- Costs nothing
- You don't own it
- Locks the ISBN to that distributor

BOUGHT (BOWKER / NATIONAL AGENCY)

You buy your own block. You are listed as publisher.

- Costs \$125 per ISBN in the US, ~R150 free in South Africa via the National Library
- You own and control it forever
- Use the same ISBN across every platform

You already have one — **978-1-0492-8329-6** — so this is solved. Use it everywhere.

SECTION IV

Technical Export

Two paths to a clean EPUB.

Pick A if you're moving fast and your manuscript is in Word or Docs. Pick B if you want more control or A produces ugly output.

4.A Option A – Word or Google Docs

1. **Apply heading styles.** Highlight every chapter title and apply *Heading 1*. Sub-sections become *Heading 2*, sub-sub-sections *Heading 3*. The auto-TOC depends on this.
2. **Insert page breaks before each chapter.** Word: Insert > Page Break. Docs: Insert > Break > Page break. Place the cursor before the chapter title.
3. **Strip junk.** Use Find & Replace to remove double spaces (" " → " "), tab characters, and triple line breaks. Reflowable hates whitespace garbage.
4. **Set paragraph indent globally.** Select all → Paragraph → first-line indent 0.5" / 1.2 em. Then manually clear the indent on the first paragraph after each heading.
5. **Insert TOC.** Word: References > Table of Contents > Automatic 1. Docs: Insert > Table of contents > With links.
6. **Export.** Word – File > Export > Create EPUB. Docs – File > Download > EPUB Publication (.epub).
7. **Validate.** Drop the file into [EPUBCheck](#) (free). Fix any structural errors it reports before uploading anywhere.

4.B Option B – Calibre (free, recommended)

1. **Install Calibre** from calibre-ebook.com.
2. **Add the DOCX.** Drag your file into the library window.
3. **Edit metadata.** Right-click → *Edit metadata*. Fill title, author, series (none), tags (your seven keywords), description, language, ISBN. Drop your cover JPEG.
4. **Convert.** Click *Convert books*. Output format: **EPUB**. Then in the left rail:
 - *Look & Feel* → enable *Smarten punctuation*; line height 1.3.
 - *Structure detection* → leave defaults.
 - *Table of contents* → set *Level 1 TOC* to //h:h1; *Force use of auto-generated TOC* ON.

- *EPUB output* → check *Preserve cover aspect ratio*; flatten EPUB to a single file.

5. **Polish.** Right-click → *Polish books* → enable *Subset embedded fonts* and *Smarten punctuation*. This trims file size and fixes typographic gremlins.

6. **Open the result in Calibre's viewer** and read the first chapter, the TOC, and the back matter. Trust your eyes.

4.C Amazon KDP-specific

- Upload the **EPUB** file. Amazon now accepts EPUB directly – do *not* generate MOBI.
- Download **Kindle Previewer** (free, Mac & Windows). Open your EPUB in it. Step through every chapter on three device emulations: Kindle Paperwhite, iPhone, iPad.
- Look for: broken TOC links, runaway italics, oversized images, orphan headings at the bottom of a screen, justified-text rivers.
- Re-upload only after Previewer is clean.

QUIET TRUTH

Word's built-in EPUB export is fine for simple manuscripts but produces messier markup than Calibre. If your TOC misbehaves, your scene breaks misalign, or you see double-spaced paragraphs in Kindle Previewer – switch to Calibre. It is worth the 30-minute learning curve.

SECTION V

The Three-Hour Checklist

Twenty steps. *One sitting.*

Start at step one. Do not skip. Do not perfect. Move.

01	☐	Open manuscript in Word or Docs.	2 MIN
02	☐	Apply Heading 1 to every chapter title.	10 MIN
03	☐	Apply Heading 2 to every sub-section.	5 MIN
04	☐	Insert page break before each chapter.	5 MIN
05	☐	Find & replace double spaces and triple line breaks.	3 MIN
06	☐	Add or confirm front matter: title, copyright, dedication, foreword.	15 MIN
07	☐	Add back matter: about the author, review CTA, thank you.	10 MIN
08	☐	Insert auto-generated table of contents.	3 MIN
09	☐	Generate cover background with the AI prompt in §1.5.	15 MIN
10	☐	Lay title, subtitle, author over the background in Canva.	20 MIN
11	☐	Export cover as JPEG, 1600 × 2560, RGB.	2 MIN
12	☐	Run the squint test on the cover — fix or accept.	3 MIN
13	☐	Export manuscript as EPUB (Word or Calibre).	5 MIN

- | | | | |
|-------|--------------------------|--|--------|
| 14 | ☐ | Validate with EPUBCheck – fix any errors. | 10 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |
| 15 | ☐ | Open in Kindle Previewer; step through every chapter. | 20 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |
| 16 | ☐ | Email the EPUB to your @kindle.com address; read first chapter on phone. | 10 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |
| 17 | ☐ | Draft the 150–300 word book description (§3.2). | 15 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |
| 18 | ☐ | Confirm seven keywords from Amazon auto-complete. | 10 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |
| 19 | ☐ | Pick two categories. | 5 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |
| 20 | ☐ | Upload EPUB + cover + metadata to KDP. Submit. | 15 MIN |
| <hr/> | | | |

Total ≈ 3 hours. Stop reading. Start.

SECTION VI

Final Verification

Three pre-flight tests.

Do all three. They take fifteen minutes total and they catch the embarrassing problems before readers do.

TEST 01 — KINDLE DEVICE

Email the EPUB to your personal `@kindle.com` address (set up in your Amazon account). Open it in the Kindle app on your phone. Read the first chapter end-to-end. Note anything that looks off.

TEST 02 — TOC LINKS

From the Kindle app, open the table of contents. Tap every chapter link. Each one must jump to the right place. If any link is dead or jumps to the wrong chapter, your heading styles are inconsistent — go back to §4.A step 1.

TEST 03 — COPYRIGHT PROOF

Read the copyright page out loud, slowly. Check year, ISBN digits, your name spelling, and that “All rights reserved” is present. This is the page authors mis-publish most often.

BONUS TEST

Send the EPUB to one trusted reader and ask them: “*Does anything look weird?*” That sentence catches more bugs than any QA tool.

SECTION VII

Alternative Platforms

Same EPUB. *Small adjustments.*

Once KDP is live, the same file will travel to every other store. A few stores have quirks worth knowing.

7.1 Draft2Digital

- Distributes to Apple Books, Barnes & Noble, Kobo, Tolino, Scribd, libraries.
- Upload your DOCX or EPUB. D2D auto-generates a clean EPUB and an interactive TOC.
- Use D2D's free ISBN *only* if you don't have your own. You do — use yours.
- Untick the Amazon distribution box; you're going direct to KDP.

7.2 Smashwords — “Meatgrinder” compatibility

Smashwords still offers a legacy auto-converter affectionately called the *Meatgrinder*. It takes a single DOCX and produces every retail format. It is picky.

- ✓ Use Smashwords' free *Style Guide* DOCX template as the base for upload.
- ✓ Strip every embedded image except the cover.
- ✓ Use only built-in heading styles — no custom styles, no manual font changes.
- ✓ No tables, no text boxes, no headers/footers, no page numbers in the manuscript.
- ✓ Leave only one blank line between paragraphs at most.

Once it passes the Meatgrinder, Smashwords admits the book to its Premium Catalog — which gets you onto Apple, Kobo, Scribd, and library systems Smashwords serves directly. You can also upload your already-clean EPUB; recent updates accept it.

7.3 Kobo Writing Life & Google Play Books

- Both accept your EPUB as-is.
- Kobo lets you set country-specific pricing — useful if you want a lower South African price and a higher US/UK price.
- Google Play converts EPUB to its own format and applies aggressive image compression. Provide higher-resolution images than you would for KDP.

7.4 Apple Books

- Best route is via D2D unless you have a Mac (then use Apple Books for Authors directly).
- Apple is strict about EPUB validation – if EPUBCheck passes, Apple will too.

SECTION VIII

If You Get Stuck

A decision tree.

Read down the left until you find your symptom. The right column is the next move.

IF — COVER FAILS KDP UPLOAD

Wrong dimensions, file too large, or “image quality is too low.”

THEN

Re-export at exactly 1600 × 2560, JPEG quality 90, RGB. Compress with TinyJPG if > 5 MB. If quality warning persists, regenerate the source at 2× and downscale.

IF — EPUB WON'T VALIDATE

EPUBCheck reports errors — usually missing alt text, broken links, malformed XHTML.

THEN

Open the EPUB in Calibre's editor (*Edit book*). Each error names a file and line. Fix top to bottom. The most common: empty <a> tags from auto-TOC, missing image alt, and stray elements from Word.

IF — TOC DOESN'T LINK

Tapping chapter titles does nothing, or jumps to the wrong place.

THEN

Your headings aren't styled consistently. Re-apply Heading 1 to every chapter title (and only chapter titles). Regenerate the TOC. Re-export.

IF — TEXT LOOKS FINE IN WORD BUT UGLY IN KINDLE PREVIEWER

Indents missing, fonts wrong, double line spacing.

THEN

Word's direct-to-EPUB export is leaking custom styles. Re-export through Calibre instead. Calibre normalises CSS and produces cleaner output 90 % of the time.

IF — KDP REJECTS “CONTENT QUALITY” AFTER SUBMISSION

Email from Amazon about formatting issues.

THEN

The email lists specific page numbers. Open in Kindle Previewer at exactly those pages. Fix and re-upload — KDP allows unlimited resubmissions before launch.

IF — YOUR BOOK ISN'T GETTING IMPRESSIONS AFTER A WEEK

Listing live, but no traffic.

THEN

Categories are likely too broad. Email kdp-categories@amazon.com with up to ten more specific sub-categories. Refresh keywords with auto-complete data. Consider a \$20/day Amazon Ads campaign on your own keywords for the first 14 days.

SECTION IX

Final Word

Done is better than *perfect*.

Stop overthinking it. You have a finished manuscript — that already places you ahead of almost everyone who ever said they would write a book. The next three steps are not difficult; they are simply unfamiliar. Do them in order, do them today.

1. Create the cover image.
2. Format the interior using §2.
3. Upload to KDP.

Your book — *Renaissance of the Poor Soul* — is for every soul that has wandered, wept, and waited. Somewhere out there is a reader who needs the next page you wrote. They cannot read it while it sits unpublished on your laptop.

*“Fika Nkosi la ngingafikanga khona mina.”
Lord, reach beyond the limits of my prayer.*

— MR E MKHIZE

Ship the book. The polish can come in version two.